



performance in the Next Generation Cup, defeating the academy teams of Aston Villa 2-0 and Everton 2-1 in consecutive games.

It finished above three of the four participating sides from England — Everton, Villa, and Crystal Palace — securing third place in the tournament, the highest achievement by an Indian team in five editions.

"I am very proud of these guys; they deserve it," said Punjab's head coach, Sankarlal Chakraborty (**left**), to *Sportstar*. "As an Indian side, we beat a European side, and I am very happy."

What worked for Punjab FC?

Punjab entered the tournament as the winner of the Reliance Foundation Development League, defeating East Bengal 3-2 in the final.

In London, it stuck to its plan of practising through small-sided games, focusing on 1v1 challenges

Strong statement: Punjab FC players celebrate their victory against Everton.

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and absorbing pressure. While the team narrowly lost 2-3 to Villa in its opener and 0-3 to Tottenham Hotspur next, it pulled off a Houdini act against Everton in the third game.

Trailing 0-1 against Everton (coached by club legend Leighton Baines), at halftime, Manglenthang Kipgen started the comeback, beating goalkeeper George Pickford at the far post. Usham Thougamba Singh completed the turnaround eight minutes from time.

"This is not just a (Punjab) team here; it is carrying India's flag," an emotional Sankarlal said, adding, "This win will be a reference point for the upcoming generations and clubs for development through academies."

In its final match, it beat Villa 2-0 to conclude a historic campaign in the Next Gen Cup.

What set Punjab apart from the other two Indian teams, East Bengal and Muthoot Football Academy, was its strategy to continuously attack and try to regain possession as quickly as possible.

Though its speed in getting the ball was slower compared to the

English teams, Punjab appeared quicker and more sure-footed in possession.

"At the youth level, we also have the potential to fight. But, in my experience, I have seen them (youth sides) play very defensively, celebrating losses by smaller margins or even conceding fewer goals," said the coach, who idolises Pep Guardiola and Subhash Bhowmik.

"So, I took it as a challenge to go against it, remove the fear of losing and conceding, and to play more attacking football," he added.

For East Bengal, the repetition of the same mistakes remained a consistent narrative, while for Muthoot, spending too much time on the ball left it second-best in most of its matches.

Ripple effect on Indian football

One of the first things that Punjab's coach did on the team bus after securing third place was to ask his boys to keep their feet on the ground and maintain consistency.

Though the matches in England

On the charge:

Muthoot FA's Mohammed Enas in action against Everton. PREMIER LEAGUE FOR INDIA

